Chess cheat sheet

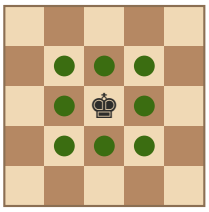
Goal: trap the enemy king (checkmate). White moves first.

How the pieces move

● can move there ● captures only ○ first move only

♔ King

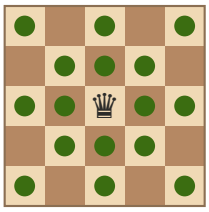
value: the game



One square in any direction. Never into an attacked square. Special: castling.

♕ Queen

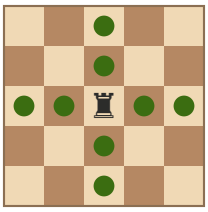
value: 9



Any distance, straight or diagonal. Strongest piece - keep her home early.

♖ Rook

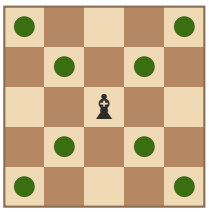
value: 5



Any distance, horizontal or vertical. Can't jump. Castles with the king.

♗ Bishop

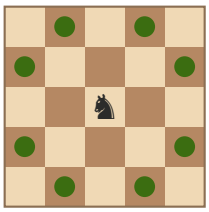
value: 3



Any distance, diagonally. Can't jump. Stays on one color all game.

♘ Knight

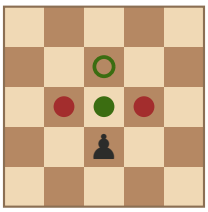
value: 3



Moves in an L (2 + 1). The only piece that jumps over others.

♙ Pawn

value: 1



Forward 1 (2 from start), never back. Captures diagonally. Promotes on the last rank.

Turn rules

- White moves first; one move per turn - passing is not allowed.
- You may never capture your own pieces or leave your own king in check.
- Formal games: touch a piece, you must move it.

Check, checkmate, stalemate

- Check - your king is attacked. Escape by moving the king, blocking, or capturing the attacker.
- Checkmate - check with no legal escape. Game over; the attacker wins.
- Stalemate - no legal moves but NOT in check. A draw, not a win - careful when far ahead.

Draws

- By agreement, stalemate, threefold repetition of a position, 50 moves with no capture or pawn move, or insufficient material to mate.

Special moves

- Castling: king slides 2 squares toward a rook; the rook hops over. Only if neither has moved, the path is clear, and the king is not in or crossing check.
- Promotion: a pawn reaching the far rank becomes a queen (or rook, bishop, knight).
- En passant: if an enemy pawn jumps 2 squares and lands beside yours, capture it diagonally - only on the very next move.

Win-fast opening checklist

- Push a center pawn (e4 or d4); fight for the center squares.
- Develop knights before bishops, toward the center. Castle by move 6-8.
- Don't bring the queen out early; don't move the same piece twice without reason.
- Before every move: is anything of mine hanging? Can I take anything for free?
- Trap to know: Scholar's mate - 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Qh5 Nf6?? 4.Qxf7# (defend with ...g6 or ...Qe7).

Fair trades: knight = bishop = 3 pawns; rook = 5; queen = 9.

Setup tip: the queen starts on her own color (d1 / d8).